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My Disappointment

I was confident in my mind that I could beat the competition, no matter how good they were. The competition was held in Orlando, Florida, and was for the Business Professionals of America nationals event. The individual event that I was competing in was Cisco Systems Administration, in which a test would be given on the criteria of knowing how to operate Cisco networking equipment and how different network topologies and protocols function. I finally got to take the test, and when the results came in, I did not place in the top ten. Even though not winning the competition was a disappointment, I made the decision to continue.

I completed every task that I could think of to help me prepare for the test. I borrowed the complete CCNA course in book form from the teacher. CCNA stands for Cisco Certified Network Associate, and is an elaborate name for the certification obtained after passing the class. I read over it and reviewed as much as I could, while reading ahead in the book over the material that had not been covered yet, granted it was not that much. The teacher also sat down with me to review questions that might appear on the test and what the correct answers would be. He provided me with a computer program that generated test questions. Despite the fact that the test at the competition was only going to be multiple choice, the test generator supplied multiple choice, matching, and simulation questions. These features helped me immensely in gaining an edge over my competition. The last major key that assisted me in preparing was doing the Cisco labs. The labs had a scenario built and the person doing the lab would have to physically set up equipment, program the correct commands into the equipment, and test the results. All of

these factors helped me to gain an edge in the competition.

When the week had come to leave to Orlando, Florida for the competition, I became nervous. I felt as if I needed to study more so that I would have left no stone unturned. I was scheduled to take my test on the first night. I knew that would be best as I did not want to forget any information that I had been cramming into my brain in the last couple of weeks. As I entered the big conference room where the test was held, I began to feel more confident and tried to relax. As I read each question on the test, I took my time in deciding what my answer would be. Test taking time was in the back of my mind, too. If there was a tie in scores, the person with the shortest time would be ranked first. I finished my test and brought it to the judges. I let out a sigh of relief, as I was glad the agony was over. The awards ceremony was not for another two nights, though, and I was very anxious to get my results. I knew in my mind that I was going to come out on top.

When the awards ceremony began, the group was excited. We were all hoping that we placed in our events. Before my competition's awards were called out, two of my friends' competitions had been called, and they both had placed in the top ten. I knew that if they had placed, then so had I. As the announcer began rattling off the names of the top ten individuals that had placed, I became very nervous. As the announcer went on, I counted on my hands how many names were left. As each finger came up, I was more nervous. When my tenth finger rose, and my name was not called, I knew that I had blew it. I had not placed in the top ten in Cisco Systems Administration. I felt I had let myself down. I began to tell myself that I did not work hard enough and did not study to the best of my ability. I had let my school down. Though I had been confident in my knowledge of the material, I underestimated the other competitors.

Even though I did not win and was very disappointed in myself, I made the decision to continue. I found out that it was going to take a lot more of determination and hard work to

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excel in my skills. With knowing that my actual Cisco exam was within a couple of weeks, I

studied even more. When the test came around, I was confident that I could pass. As I submitted the last question of the test, I held my breath. When the results came up, I was not surprised. I had almost made a perfect score.